

MODERN WORKPLACE ENGINEERING

LaunchPad

Build something real.

Theme: Where's My Desk ?



Duration: 2 Days | Format: In-Person | 11–12 May 2026

LaunchPad

Giving new ideas liftoff!

LaunchPad is the hackathon programme for Modern Workplace Engineering. It runs bi-annually, giving our engineers dedicated time and space to build, experiment, and innovate beyond the constraints of day-to-day delivery.

Each edition takes on a real problem. The best ideas will be taken forward into product delivery and backlog refinement.

'26

11–12 May 2026 · Leeds

What is a hackathon?

A hackathon is an event where people engage in rapid, collaborative engineering over a short, fixed period — typically 24 to 48 hours. The goal is to produce something real by the end.

Collaborate

Mixed teams of engineers, designers, and domain thinkers working toward a shared goal.

Build

Functioning software, not slides. Something demoable exists at the end of every hackathon.

Impact

The strongest ideas move forward. Winning concepts feed directly into what gets designed and built.

Hackathons bring together people with different skills — engineers, designers, product thinkers — and give them a focused problem, a hard deadline, and the freedom to approach it however they choose. The constraint is the point: two days forces decisions, surfaces creative thinking, and produces something tangible.

They're also a proven vehicle for skill development. Participants build problem-solving, critical thinking, and hands-on experience with tools and technologies they might not touch in their day jobs — including AI-assisted development.

Hackathon: from “hack” (exploratory programming) + “marathon” — rapid, collaborative engineering toward a real outcome.

What & Why



The Problem

Following the delivery of the Group Location Strategy, many office buildings are now at or near full capacity. While this improves space utilization, it has introduced challenges for colleagues who want to book desks and collaborate effectively within the office.

- Today, colleagues often struggle to:
- Sit near their team or key collaborators
- See when colleagues will be in the office to allow for pre-planning
- Understand desk availability once they arrive on a floor
- Manage bookings flexibly when their plans change
- Remember to check in or cancel bookings which leads to blocked capacity
- Identify Desks with the right equipment or attributes for their needs

Additionally, the current desk booking system:

- Has poor integration with the wider workplace toolset
- Has vendor-imposed API limitations that create bottlenecks
- Has limitations in data analytics and reporting, meaning insights are hard to analyse and act upon



Why a Hackathon?



We've all felt the pain of the current system — that makes us well placed to build something better.



We're at the start of our AI adoption journey. This is a vehicle to trial LLMs and build real hands-on experience.



The best ideas won't be shelved — they'll feed into a formal requirements specification for a future enterprise-grade implementation.



It builds a culture of innovation and experimentation, not just operating.



It exposes our engineers to what AI makes possible and builds familiarity with new ways of working.



It brings our engineers together — building relationships, socialising, and getting face time that distributed teams rarely get.

The Challenge

Design and build a desk booking system that you'd actually want to use — solving the real challenges of hybrid workplace management for a large, distributed organisation.



Pre-requisites

- You team shall be provided with a Claude platform workspace and api key on the day. The api key will be credited with \$240 for your team
- Install a IDE tool (e.g. VS Code) and set up Claude Code CLI before the hackathon — see <https://code.claude.com/docs/en/overview>
- A personal GitHub account is required
- Bring a personal device for the duration of the hack to build your solution



Constraints

- Synthetic data only — no real org data should be used at any point
- No mandatory deployment target — but must be demoable live or by recording
- External APIs used must be publicly accessible
- Build freeze at 13:30 on Day 2 — demo prep only after
- One submission per team
- All work should be inside your fork of the LaunchPad git repo as part of the submission



Your Team

- 3–5 people per team
- Optionally nominate a team captain — single point of contact for your mentor and the organising lead
- Your private GitHub repo will be waiting — invites go out once teams are confirmed
- A mentor will be assigned to your team — one per two teams, they are there to unblock not to build
- One submission per team — whatever's on your branch at build freeze is what you demo



Rules of Engagement

- Respect the room — different backgrounds and experience levels, make everyone feel welcome
- Share mentor time fairly — mentors cover two teams, don't monopolise
- Escalate early — if something's blocking you for more than 30 minutes, flag to your mentor
- Demos are for everyone — laptops closed during other teams' presentations, full attention in the room

The Problem Space

These aren't requirements — they're prompts to provide context. Good solutions will address some of these. Great solutions might reframe them entirely.

Finding & Booking

? How does someone know which desks are actually available before they decide to come in?

? What does booking for a morning versus a full day mean for the space — and the people who need it next?

? If someone books a desk and doesn't show up, what should happen to it?

? How does the experience differ for someone booking on behalf of a colleague?

Awareness & Coordination

? How does someone know whether their team will be in the office on the same day they're planning to attend?

? If you want to sit near your team, how does the system help you find them — or bring you together?

? What happens when a team of six all need to be in the same area on the same day?

? At what point does desk occupancy visibility become useful — and at what point does it become intrusive?

Management & Oversight

? How does someone responsible for a floor know how it's being used — and whether it's being used well?

? A desk is more than a surface. What attributes about a space might matter to the person booking it?

? If the organisation wants to understand attendance patterns over time, what should the system be producing?

? Who should be able to control which desks are available, when, and for whom?

Side Quests

1 of 2

Extra angles worth exploring if your team finishes the core build — or spots one of these as a novel problem they want to solve. Pick one, several, or none. No penalty for sticking to the fundamentals.



First-Time Fit

Help colleagues find a desk that genuinely matches their needs on the first try — not through trial and error. Go beyond equipment filters: think about the signals that make a desk right for the task, the person, or the day.

- ? What makes a desk the “right” one for a given colleague or task?
- ? How do we surface the right desks without burying people in choice?
- ? Should past bookings inform future suggestions — and how visibly?



Arrival Confidence

Give colleagues certainty before they travel. How does someone know — ahead of setting off — that they’ll find a suitable desk when they walk in? Surface the signal, not just the seat count.

- ? What level of certainty is enough to commit to a journey in?
- ? How do you signal likely availability on the floor, not just the building?
- ? What happens when confidence is low — do you suggest alternatives?



Environmental

Temperature, natural light, noise, airflow, proximity to a window or aircon vent. These quietly shape whether a desk works for someone. How could these influence choice without turning booking into a form-filling exercise?

- ? Which environmental signals are worth capturing — and how?
- ? Sensor data, colleague feedback, or both? Who owns the source of truth?
- ? How do personal preferences get matched to the space without friction?

Side Quests

2 of 2

Continued from the previous slide. Same rules — these are optional, not ranked, and each is a distinct angle on the problem space.



Friction-Free Change

Plans shift. Meetings move, children get sick, the train is cancelled. How does someone cancel, shorten, swap, or hand over a booking in seconds — and how does the freed capacity get back into circulation cleanly?



Predictable Hot Desking

Hot desking fails when it feels random. How might the system make it feel reliable — returning someone to a familiar desk, recognising routines, or letting teams hold a cluster across days without locking the space down?



Behavioural Nudges

Most desk-booking problems are behavioural, not technical. How might the system gently shape better habits — timely reminders, social visibility, smart defaults — without policing people or stacking up policy?



Adaptive Booking Rules

One rule rarely fits every case. Team bookings, anchor days, all-hands, training cohorts, visitor groups — how might the rules flex for the use case in front of them without becoming restrictive for the everyday booker?

Format & Schedule

In-person. A shared MS Teams channel will be used for announcements and async updates throughout both days.

Day 1 — Build

Monday 11th May

10:00	Welcome & kick-off
10:10	Product owner brief — the problem space
10:20	Team formation, repo setup & questions
10:45	Hack begins
13:00	Pizza lunch — on the company
13:30	Afternoon build session
15:30	Mid-hack review
17:30	Close
18:00	Drinks — own tab, all welcome
19:00	Dinner — own tab, all welcome

Day 2 — Build, Demo & Judge

Tuesday 12th May

09:00	Morning build session
12:30	Lunch (own tab) & build freeze prep
13:30	Build freeze — demo prep only
14:30	Presentations (10 min each)
16:00	Judging & deliberation
16:30	Winners announced
17:00	Close

Judging

Every team is assessed against all categories automatically. You can win one category, several, or the overall prize.



Best in Show

Overall winner — highest combined score across all categories. Winning ideas are pooled into a requirements specification for a future enterprise-grade implementation.

 Winning team members each receive £50 in game changer points

JUDGING CATEGORIES



Best Demo

Working prototype, shown live, with supporting artifacts and story



Best Technical Approach

Sound architecture, defensible technology choices, clear path to productionizing



Best UX

A non-technical person understands your solution intuitively. User journey's are clear



Best Feature Fit

Feature choices map clearly to the problem space. The team built what mattered, not just what was obvious.



Most Innovative

Something unexpected — a side quest achieved, a clever idea, a wow moment.

Results announced at 16:30 on Day 2. Mixed panel — with product owners and engineering leads.

Event Roles & Assignments

For organiser use only

ROLE	RESPONSIBILITIES	ASSIGNED TO
MC	Runs both days end-to-end. Opens proceedings, keeps schedule, introduces sessions, manages demo timing on Day 2, and announces winners.	Dafydd Watkins
Judge (×3)	Attends Day 2 afternoon in full. Scores all teams across all five categories independently. Participates in deliberation and tie-break vote. Panel is briefed by Hackathon Mentor observations ahead of demos.	Dafydd Watkins James Stacey Joshua Ross
Guest Speaker <i>optional</i>	Delivers a short talk on Day 1 to set context and energy. Topic and slot agreed with speaker in advance. Leave unassigned if not confirmed.	N/A
Hackathon Mentor <i>1 per 2 teams</i>	Assigned to two teams throughout both days. Unblocks technical problems without building for teams, observes quality and progress, and feeds assessments to the Organising Lead ahead of the judging panel.	Joseph Little Bob Williams Stephan Henry Hugh O'neil
Photographer	Captures both days — build sessions, mid-hack energy, demo moments, and winner announcement. Records Day 2 presentations for post-event use.	TBC
Logistics	Supports with organizing rooms, etc	Chelsea Knowles

Blueprint

Welcome & Housekeeping

Welcome to LaunchPad '26 - 'where's my desk?!' two days to step away from BAU, build something real, and work with people across the directorate you don't normally get time with. Glad you're here.



Fire Safety

- No fire alarms are scheduled today. If one sounds, treat it as real.
- Follow the building directions and vacate promptly.
- Nearest fire exits are signposted on the floor — note them on your way to your table.
- Assembly point: as directed by fire marshals on exit.



Spaces

- Hack room: Floor 10, Event Space — your team table is home base.
- Day 1 (today): Spare room 10-02 · Quiet room 10-03
- Day 2: Spare room 08-05 · Quiet room 09-08
- Spare = overflow, breakouts, hack mentor 1:1s.
- Quiet = heads-down or need time to decompress space.



Credentials & kit

- Azure credentials are on a printed card at your table — use if you want to deploy there.
- Claude API keys — Joe will come round to each team with yours.
- WiFi: connect to STONEHENGE.
- MS Teams channel is live — will be used it for async questions and announcements.



Photography, recording & demos

- We'll be taking photos and video today for internal and promotional use.
- Not happy being in shots? Let me or the photographer know and we'll work around you.
- Demos can be live or pre-recorded tomorrow — team's call. Pick whichever gives you the cleanest story.
- Day 2 presentations will be recorded for post-event sharing.

Format & Schedule

In-person. A shared MS Teams channel will be used for announcements and async updates throughout both days.

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Day 2 — Build, Demo & Judge

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17:00	Close

Abstract requirements for the event — what any suitable venue must be able to accommodate. See room profile slides for location-specific details.

LAYOUT

Format Carousel / cabaret — round or cluster tables, one per team

Team tables Up to 5 per table, up to 8 teams — confirm count post-registration

Stationery Notepads, sticky notes, whiteboard pens per table

Power Extension leads — min. 4 outlets per team table

Pre-event check Room fully configured the working day before Day 1

ATTENDEES

Target capacity Up to 40 participants, plus judges and organising team on top

Attendee type Internal only — no external attendees for this edition

Judges 3 — present for Day 2 afternoon only

Hackathon Mentors 1 per 2 teams — count confirmed post-registration

Travel Non-local attendees book promptly after registration closes

AV REQUIREMENTS

Display Min. one large screen visible from all team positions

Connectivity HDMI or wireless connection for presenting team laptops

Team devices Teams bring own laptops — one dedicated device per person

Adapters Organisers carry spare HDMI and USB-C adapters on the day

CATERING REQUIREMENTS

Coverage Morning refreshments, working lunch, afternoon break — both days

Delivery Working lunch delivered to team tables — no separate catering area

Timing Lunch at 12:30 both days

Headcount Confirmed participant count + 2 buffer — submit 5 days before

Dietary Collected via registration form — pass to supplier in advance

Your Role & Boundaries

You're assigned to two teams. Your job is to keep them moving — not to build for them. The outcome belongs to the team. Read this before the day and come ready.

WHAT YOU'RE HERE TO DO

Keep teams unblocked. If a team is stuck on a technical problem that's burning time, help them get past it. Point them in the right direction — don't solve it for them.

Observe, don't steer. Watch how each team is working — their approach, their decisions, their use of AI tooling. These observations feed directly into your mid-point scoring.

Check in regularly. Touch base with each of your two teams at least once per hour. You're not hovering — you're making yourself available.

Complete the scoring sheet at 15:30. One sheet per team using the scoring rubric. Hand your completed sheets to the Organising Lead before the end of the mid-hack review.

Escalate blockers. If a team has a problem you can't help with — access, tooling, logistics — flag it to the Organising Lead immediately rather than letting it sit.

WHERE THE LINE IS

Don't write code for a team. Not even a quick fix. If you touch the keyboard, the output stops being theirs.

Don't make architectural decisions. You can ask questions that help them think it through. You can't tell them what to build or how to structure it.

Don't play favourites. Give both your teams equal time and attention. Don't let one dominate because they're more vocal or technically familiar to you.

Don't share what other teams are building. You'll see across multiple teams. Keep what you observe confidential between them.

Don't rescue teams from productive struggle. Being stuck and working through it is part of the process. Only step in if progress has genuinely stalled.

On the Day

11:00

Hack begins

Introduce yourself to both teams. Make sure they know you're their point of contact. Remind them you're there to help them get unblocked — not to review their work. Read the hack brief so you know what they're working toward.

11-15:30

Build phase

Check in with each team at least once per hour. Note how they're approaching the problem, how they're using AI tooling, and where they're making trade-offs. These observations go into your scoring sheet at 15:30. Begin completing your notes as you go — don't leave it to the last minute.

15:30

Mid-hack review

Complete one scoring sheet per team using the scoring rubric in this deck. Score independently — do not discuss with other mentors before submitting. Hand both completed sheets to the Organising Lead before the end of the review session.

Your reference documents: Hack Brief (shared 3 days before the event) · Scoring Rubric (see appendix of this deck) · Team assignments (confirmed post-registration)

Event Space, Floor 10 — Wellington Place, Leeds

✓ Spec confirmed

ROOM

Rated capacity 100-person room — seats 50 comfortably in cabaret layout
Shape Long format — suits cabaret / carousel layout
Location Floor 10, Wellington Place, Leeds
Access Confirm early-entry arrangements with building management
Spec fit Accommodates up to 40 with comfortable headroom

CATERING PROVISION

Supplier Venue arranging — confirm with building / facilities team
Delivery method In-room delivery to tables — confirm this is supported by venue
Order deadline Confirm headcount and dietary requirements by 6 May
Evening Drinks social (18:00) and dinner (19:00) on Day 1 — venue TBC

AV PROVISION

Screens 2 screens distributed across the length of the room
Connectivity TBC — confirm HDMI / wireless with venue before event
Spec fit Exceeds minimum — 2 screens cover long-format room well
Pre-event test Test both screens during Friday 9 May pre-check visit

OPEN ITEMS

AV connectivity HDMI vs wireless for both screens — confirm with venue
Room booking Confirm room is booked for both days inc. Fri 9 May setup visit
Evening venue Drinks and dinner location for Day 1 evening not yet confirmed
WiFi External WiFi access and speed on Floor 10 — test during pre-check

ROOM BOOKING · LAYOUT · AV · CATERING		ASSIGNEE →	ASSIGNEE →
☐ Book hack room for both days — 100-person room, seats 50 comfortably, max 40 in attendance		☐ Confirm connectivity for both screens with venue — HDMI or wireless (TBC)	
☐ Configure room layout — carousel / cabaret, one table per team, working lunch delivered to desks		☐ Test both screens end-to-end before Day 1 — not on the morning itself	
☐ Source extension leads and power strips — min. 4 outlets per team table		☐ Confirm catering order with venue — working lunch to desks, dietary requirements, timing	
☐ Confirm building access for early setup — keys or access passes arranged		☐ Send final headcount to venue 5 days before event — include +2 buffer	
☐ Print room assets — team name cards, day schedule poster, QR codes to repo. Source notepads, sticky notes, and whiteboard pens for each team table		☐ Friday 9 May pre-check — room layout, stationery at tables, AV, screens, and power all confirmed in person. Do not leave this for Day 1 morning	

Organiser Blueprint · Event Roles & Assignments

For organiser use only

ROLE	RESPONSIBILITIES	ASSIGNED TO
MC	Runs both days end-to-end. Opens proceedings, keeps schedule, introduces sessions, manages demo timing on Day 2, and announces winners.	_____
Judge (×3)	Attends Day 2 afternoon in full. Scores all teams across all five categories independently. Participates in deliberation and tie-break vote. Panel is briefed by Hackathon Mentor observations ahead of demos.	_____ _____ _____
Guest Speaker <i>optional</i>	Delivers a short talk on Day 1 to set context and energy. Topic and slot agreed with speaker in advance. Leave unassigned if not confirmed.	_____
Hackathon Mentor <i>1 per 2 teams</i>	Assigned to two teams throughout both days. Unblocks technical problems without building for teams, observes quality and progress, and feeds assessments to the Organising Lead ahead of the judging panel.	_____
Photographer	Captures both days — build sessions, mid-hack energy, demo moments, and winner announcement. Records Day 2 presentations for post-event use.	_____
Organising Lead	Overall accountability. Receives Hackathon Mentor observations throughout both days, aggregates them ahead of judging, collects and tallies judge scoring sheets, confirms winners privately before announcement, and owns post-event follow-through.	_____

Organiser Blueprint — Participant Email Template

For organiser use only

Subject: We're running a Hackathon — and we want you in it

Hi all,

We're running the first Modern Workplaces Engineering Hackathon on Monday 11th and Tuesday 12th May, and we're looking for teams to take part.

The theme will be related to modernizing a system we all frequently use and giving you the space to innovate and imagine a better way of implementing this kind of service.

This isn't about writing perfect code. It's about ideas, experimentation, and getting hands-on with AI-assisted development. The best concepts from across all teams will feed into a formal requirements specification for a future implementation.

What to expect:

- Two days of focused building in a dedicated space in Leeds
- A real problem to solve, with synthetic data and API sandbox credentials provided
- Tracks to compete in — Best Demo, Best UX, Best Technical Approach, Best Feature Fit, Most Innovative — with prizes for each
- An overall Best in Show prize for the strongest all-round entry

Teams are self-organising — form a group of 3–5 with people you want to work with. If you don't have a team yet, let us know and we'll help place you.

Assets and the briefing materials will be released on Thursday 8th May — one working day before the event.

To register, confirm your attendance with your engineering lead and reply to this email with your team name and members by Tuesday April 21st. Questions? Drop them in [channel TBD].

Looking forward to seeing what we build.

[Your name] — Modern Workplaces Engineering

MC

Can be from the organising team or a confident external voice. Should have charisma, be comfortable in front of a room, and keep things moving without the day feeling like it's being managed at them.

RESPONSIBILITIES

Open both days. Welcome the room, introduce yourself, and set the tone. Relaxed and informational — not a corporate briefing.

Run the Day 1 schedule. Outline the day's flow at the start: timings, key moments, fire safety and building logistics, where to find things. Make it quick.

Introduce sessions. Bring on the product owner brief, the guest speaker if present, and any other structured slots. Keep handovers clean.

Keep time. You own the schedule. If a session is running long, cut it. If the room needs energy, give it some.

Run Day 2 demos. Manage presenter order, keep each team to their slot, and maintain energy in the room as the day progresses.

Deliver the winner announcement. See the scripted announcement in the following section. You can go off-piste, but the structure and category order should be followed.

WINNER ANNOUNCEMENT SCRIPT

"Right — the judges have deliberated. We have five category prizes to announce and one overall winner. In no particular order of category... [pause]
Best Demo goes to [team name]. Best Technical Approach goes to [team name]. Best UX goes to [team name]. Best Feature Fit goes to [team name]. Most Innovative goes to [team name].
And finally — Best in Show. The highest combined score across all categories. That goes to... [pause] ...[team name]. Congratulations."
You can go off-piste with the delivery — add colour, build suspense — but follow the category order and save Best in Show for last. Confirm all winner names with the Organising Lead before taking the stage.

Judge

Present for Day 2 afternoon only. You score all teams independently — your assessment isn't discussed with other judges until deliberation. You will receive a written observation summary from the Hackathon Mentors before demos begin, organised by judging category, to provide context on each team's build process.

RESPONSIBILITIES

Attend the full Demo Day afternoon. Arrive before 14:30. You will be seated and given the Hackathon Mentor observation summaries to read before presentations begin.

Watch every team present. Each team has 10 minutes. Watch their demo, note how clearly they communicate their decisions, and observe how the product addresses the problem space.

Score independently. Complete your scoring sheet for every team across all five categories using the rubric in this deck. Do not discuss scores with other judges before the deliberation session.

Participate in deliberation. After all presentations, the judging panel meets. Share your scores and reasoning. Resolve any ties by panel vote.

Confirm results to the Organising Lead. Do not share results publicly. Pass your completed scoring sheet to the Organising Lead. The MC announces winners — not the judges.

Guest Speaker

Optional slot on Day 1. You have 10 minutes. Your job is to set context and energy for the room before the build begins — not to pitch, not to teach, not to demonstrate a product. The best talks here are honest, specific, and short.

SPEAKER NOTES

Know your audience. These are engineers who are about to build something under time pressure. They want to be inspired and informed, not sold to. Speak to the craft.

Keep it to 10 minutes. This is a hard limit. The schedule is tight and the room needs to get building. Prepare for exactly 10 minutes and stop.

Ground it in the theme. If the hack has a technology theme — e.g. AI-assisted development — speak to your experience with it. What worked, what surprised you, what you'd do differently.

Leave them ready to go. End with something that sends energy into the room. A provocation, a challenge, a moment that makes them want to open a laptop.

No Q&A. There is no time. Questions can be picked up informally during the build day if attendees want to find you.

Photographer

Can be someone from the team with a decent phone. The objective is to capture collateral that can be used in post-event comms across MS Teams, Viva Engage, and any internal write-up or leadership summary. Shoot candidly — the best content looks like things actually happened, not like a staged photo call.

KEY MOMENTS TO CAPTURE

Teams at work. Candid shots of people building — screens, whiteboards, conversations. The energy of a room full of engineers solving a problem.

The mid-hack review on day 1 (15:30). Teams gathered, mentors present. A natural moment that shows the event in motion.

Day 2 demos. Each team presenting. Capture the presenter and the screen if possible. Get the room reaction.

The winner announcement. The moment winners are called. Genuine reactions. This is the headline shot for any post-event write-up.

Group shot. End of Day 2, full room. Get everyone in. This is the social media / Viva Engage anchor image.

Output destinations. MS Teams LaunchPad channel (during and after the event), Viva Engage post-event write-up, and any internal leadership summary. Share a selection within 48 hours. Raw images to the Organising Lead.

Organising Lead

Accountable for the event programme and outcomes. This is not the logistics role — see Logistics Lead for venue, catering, and setup. Your focus is on the people, the process, and what the event produces.

RESPONSIBILITIES

Brief and assign the judging panel. Confirm judges in advance. Brief them on the format, the scoring rubric, and how the Hackathon Mentor observations will be shared with them before demos.

Receive Hackathon Mentor observations. Collect completed mid-hack observation sheets from all mentors at the 15:30 review. Aggregate and prepare a written summary per team, organised by judging category, to share with judges before Day 2 presentations.

Manage the judging process. Ensure judges score independently. Collect completed scoring sheets. Tally scores and resolve any ties. Confirm winners privately before the announcement.

Brief the MC. Confirm winner names with the MC before they take the stage. Do not share results with the room before the announcement.

Own post-event follow-through. Ensure winning ideas are captured and fed into a formal requirements process. Circulate a post-event summary to participants and stakeholders. Share photography via Teams and Viva Engage.

Be the point of escalation on the day. If anything goes wrong — logistics, technical, personnel — it comes to you. Have a clear line to the Logistics Lead for anything operational.

Logistics Lead

Responsible for everything that makes the physical event work. You own the venue relationship, catering, equipment, and day-of setup. The Organising Lead should be able to focus entirely on the programme knowing you have the operational side covered.

RESPONSIBILITIES

Own the venue relationship. Confirm room bookings including the pre-event setup visit (Friday before). Liaise with building management on access, AV connectivity, and any restrictions.

Manage catering. Confirm the catering order for both days. Collect dietary requirements from the registration form and pass to the supplier. Submit the final headcount at least 5 days before the event.

Set up the room. Arrange tables in carousel/cabaret layout. Place stationery per table. Confirm power, screens, and AV ahead of Day 1. Complete the pre-event room check on the Friday.

Hold spare equipment on the day. Keep spare HDMI and USB-C adapters on hand. Be the go-to person for anything practical that needs fixing.

Manage travel coordination. Prompt non-local attendees to book travel promptly after registration closes. Be the point of contact for any travel or access queries.

Support the evening social. Confirm the venue for Day 1 drinks and dinner (if applicable). Communicate details to attendees in advance. See the schedule notes slide for budget and framing guidance.

Organiser Blueprint · MS Forms Registration — Field Specification

For organiser use only

FIELD	TYPE	REQ	WHY WE NEED IT
Full name	Short text	✓	Participant identification, team confirmation comms, name cards for tables
Team name	Short text	No	Left blank if no team yet. Used to build the team roster and confirm GitHub repo assignments
Request team placement	Checkbox	No	Flags participants who need the organiser to place them. Triggers individual follow-up before Day 1
Work email address	Short text	✓	MS Forms doesn't auto-collect this. Used for all participant comms, team confirmations, and credential distribution
GitHub username	Short text	✓	Used to invite participants to their team's private repo once teams are confirmed
Dietary requirements	Long text (optional)	No	Passed to venue with the catering order. Collected once, used for both days including the evening
Accessibility / access requirements	Long text (optional)	No	Mobility, neurodivergence, or other needs that affect room setup or day-of arrangements
Confirm personal device	Checkbox	✓	Confirm that participants' have a personal device (e.g laptop) for the hackathon and set the expectation that LaunchPad not provide them with a device on the day. This should be a condition for sign up.

⚠ REQ = Required field on the form. All optional fields should include helper text explaining why we're asking and confirming the response won't affect participation.

To: Modern Workplaces Engineering

Subject: LaunchPad '26 — Register now (closes Friday 24th April)

Hi all,

Our first Hackathon LaunchPad event of '26 is happening on **11–12th May in Leeds**, and we want you there! Two days to step away from the day job, build something real, and work alongside people across the directorate you don't normally get time with. Spaces are limited so please sign up promptly if you are interested in coming.

You can sign up with a team, or sign up without a team and we'll place you into one.

The challenge will be revealed a few days before the event. All you need to do right now is sign up — the brief and everything you need to get started will follow once registration closes.

Register using the link below. It takes two minutes and closes **Friday 24th April**.

If you have any questions then please feel free to reach out to me directly

See you there.

[Your name]

Register for LaunchPad '26 →

[Insert MS Forms link here before sending]

 Add the MS Forms URL before sending. Subject line, close date, and sign-off should be personalised to the sender.

SCHEDULE TEMPLATE

10:00	Welcome & kick-off
10:10	Speaker brief — the problem space (10 min)
10:20	Questions & setup
10:45	Hack begins
13:00	Pizza lunch — on the company
15:30	Mid-hack review
17:30	Close
18:00	Drinks — own tab, all welcome
19:00	Dinner — own tab, all welcome

NOTES & CONSIDERATIONS

Start time: 10:00, not 09:00

Deliberate decision. Gives attendees travelling from across the country time to arrive without requiring an overnight stay the night before. Do not move to 09:00 unless all attendees are local.

Speaker brief (10:10) — options

Guest speaker options depend on who's available. If a sponsor is involved, they should have a slot. If the product owner is available, 10 minutes to describe the problem space works well and gives teams direct context. A senior engineer with domain knowledge is also a good fit if they can speak to the technology involved — e.g. the use of AI in a vibe-coded hack. Keep all slots to 10 minutes. Brief only — not a design session.

Team formation — do this before the day

Team formation must be completed entirely before the day. Use the registration window to confirm teams, assign GitHub repos, and resolve any placement requests. Arriving at the event with unformed teams creates avoidable confusion and eats into build time. The 10:20 slot is for questions on the brief and getting settled — not for negotiating who is in which team.

Lunch

Day 1 is typically covered by the business. Attendees will have travelled early and from distance — energy matters. Bring lunch into the room and choose food that works at a desk: no plates, no queuing, easy to eat while building. Pizza is the proven default. The goal is staying in the flow. Day 2: own tab.

Evening — drinks & dinner

Check event budget early. If budget exists, arrange a booking and cover the bill. If not, identify a good local option, reserve a table, and make clear it's on each attendee's own tab. Either way, frame it as genuinely social and optional. Attendees travelling from outside the host city may be able to offset part of the cost against their travel allowance — flag this and advise them to confirm with their expenses policy.

Organiser Blueprint — Judges Scoring Rubric

3 judges · scores out of 10 · averaged across panel



Category: Best Demo

9-10

Runs live with no caveats. Demonstrates a coherent end-to-end user flow — not just individual features, but a story that hangs together. No errors, no workarounds, no "imagine this part works."

7-8

Runs live with minor caveats. Core flow is clear but one feature is stubbed, skipped, or narrated rather than shown. A judge can see this is a working system with a small gap.

5-6

Partially working. Some features demonstrated live, others mocked or explained away. The idea is visible but the judge has to fill in blanks. The system runs in parts but not as a whole.

3-4

Mostly non-functional. Demo relies on static screens, mockups, or narrated walkthroughs. Little live interaction. The concept is present but cannot be assessed as a working system.

2

Attempted but failed. The team clearly built something and made a genuine effort, but a critical issue — deployment failure, environment problem, or technical blocker — prevented a meaningful demo. Effort is recognised.

1

No meaningful demo. Slides, diagrams, or concept only — no working system shown and no technical blocker explains the absence.



Category: Best Technical Approach

9-10

Exemplary across all dimensions. Architecture is coherent end-to-end. Team articulates why they chose their approach over alternatives. Technology choices are clear, present and meaningful. Security handled deliberately. Integration approach is clean and extensible.

7-8

Strong across most dimensions with minor gaps. Architecture is sound and decisions are defensible. Technology choices are present and coherent, with only small gaps. Security broadly correct with one or two unconsidered areas. Integration works but may not be extensible.

5-6

Functional but lacking depth. System works but team struggles to explain why. Technology choices are referenced but it's not clear why the team picked A over B. Security concerns partially addressed. Integration approach is tightly coupled or brittle. Engineering judges can see structural debt.

3-4

Limited technical thinking evident. Decisions feel reactive rather than intentional. No technology decisioning referenced, no evidence of security consideration beyond the basics. Integration is hardcoded or fragile. Team cannot defend key choices when questioned.

2

Minimal structure. Something was built but no discernible architecture. No spec, no technology explanations, no security consideration, no sensible integration pattern. Functions by luck rather than intent.

1

Nothing to assess technically. No running system, no documentation, and no evidence of architectural thinking in the presentation.

Organiser Blueprint — Judges Scoring Rubric

3 judges · scores out of 10 · averaged across panel



Category: Best UX

9-10

A non-technical person could complete a booking without any guidance. Flow is intuitive, feedback is clear at every step, errors are handled gracefully with meaningful messages. Basic accessibility present — contrast, labels, readable text. Interface feels like it belongs in a modern workplace tool.

7-8

Largely intuitive with minor friction. A new user could navigate the core flow but may hesitate at one or two points. Error states partially handled. Visually coherent. Minor accessibility gaps but nothing that blocks use.

5-6

Usable with guidance. System works but a new user would need a brief explanation to get started. Some flows feel incomplete or require trial and error. Error handling is minimal — failures may be silent or unclear.

3-4

Difficult to use without knowing how it was built. Navigation requires prior knowledge of the system's structure. Errors are unexplained or absent. The interface communicates for the developer, not the user. Accessibility ignored.

2

Barely navigable. The UI exists but provides little to no guidance. A user unfamiliar with the build would struggle to complete any meaningful action without help from the team.

1

No meaningful UX to assess. No interface, or an interface so incomplete it cannot be evaluated as a user experience.



Category: Best Feature Fit

9-10

Deliberate, well-reasoned feature choices that address the most important dimensions of the problem space. The team can articulate what they built and why — and what they chose not to build and why. Features hang together as a coherent solution. The product owner would recognise the pain points being solved.

7-8

Strong feature choices with minor gaps. The team addressed the core of the problem and made sensible scope decisions, but one or two features feel either missing or included without clear justification. The team can defend most decisions but may struggle on one or two.

5-6

Reasonable coverage but choices feel driven by what was easy to build rather than what was important to solve. The team addressed the obvious booking flow but missed meaningful parts of the problem space. Feature decisions are partially defensible.

3-4

Limited problem understanding evident in the feature choices. Built a subset of obvious features without demonstrating awareness of the broader problem space. Scope decisions feel arbitrary or driven by technical familiarity rather than user need.

2

Feature choices show little connection to the problem space. What was built doesn't meaningfully address the core desk booking challenge, or the team cannot articulate why they chose what they did.

1

No meaningful feature choices to assess. Nothing was built, or what was built bears no relationship to the problem posed.

Organiser Blueprint · Mid-Hack Observation Sheet

Hackathon Mentor use only · One sheet per team

Team name: _____ **Mentor:** _____ **Completed at:** 15:30 · Hand to Organising Lead before end of mid-hack review

Qualitative observations only — no scores. These notes give the judging panel context on each team's build process ahead of Day 2 demos. Be specific. What you saw matters more than what you expected.

BEST DEMO

Is there a working prototype? How far along are they? Likely to run live on Day 2?

BEST TECHNICAL APPROACH

What stack/approach? Are architectural decisions deliberate? How are they using AI tooling?

BEST UX

Is the team thinking about the user experience? Any design thinking visible in the build?

BEST FEATURE FIT

Are feature choices deliberate? Is the team solving the actual problem or building what's easy?

MOST INNOVATIVE

Has anything surprised you? An unexpected angle, a clever use of AI, a side quest delivered? Note the moment, not just the output.

WHAT TO DEFINE

Challenge title. Give the hack a name. Should be evocative, not purely descriptive.

One-line summary. What is the team building? Completable in one sentence.

Context and why. Why was this challenge chosen? What organisational problem does it address? This grounds the hack in something real and gives participants a reason to care.

What success looks like. Describe the direction of a good outcome — not a spec. E.g. a working prototype a non-technical user could navigate in under 30 seconds.

Constraints. What limits apply? Time is a given. Are there specific platforms, APIs, or data sets that must or must not be used? State these explicitly — ambiguity here creates friction on the day.

TECH STACK DECISION

Open-ended or prescribed? Decide explicitly before writing the participant brief. Open-ended hacks let teams choose their own stack — faster to set up, harder to judge consistently. Prescribed stacks create parity and test specific skills, but require pre-event setup and asset distribution.

If prescribed: List required technologies, frameworks, or platforms. E.g. must use Microsoft Graph API, or backend in any language but frontend must be a web app.

If open-ended: State this clearly so teams are not second-guessing. Note any platforms that are explicitly off-limits, e.g. no-code-only tools if the judging criteria reward technical approach.

Whatever you decide, communicate it clearly in the participant brief at least 3 days before the event. Tech stack ambiguity is one of the most common causes of wasted build time.

Organiser Blueprint — Problem Space

For organiser use only

This slide is participant-facing. It surfaces tensions and friction points drawn from the product owner brief — without prescribing a solution. Every entry should be a question, not a requirement. Good solutions will address some. Great solutions might reframe them entirely.

Populate this slide once the product owner brief has been confirmed. Organise prompts into 2–3 thematic domains. Aim for 3–4 questions per domain. Phrase everything as an open question.

DOMAIN 1 — [E.G. FINDING & BOOKING]

? [Prompt question surfacing friction in this domain.]

? [Prompt question.]

? [Prompt question.]

? [Prompt question.]

DOMAIN 2 — [E.G. AWARENESS & COORDINATION]

? [Prompt question surfacing friction in this domain.]

? [Prompt question.]

? [Prompt question.]

? [Prompt question.]

DOMAIN 3 — [E.G. MANAGEMENT & OVERSIGHT]

? [Prompt question surfacing friction in this domain.]

? [Prompt question.]

? [Prompt question.]

? [Prompt question.]

WHAT ARE SIDE QUESTS?

Side quests are optional bonus challenges for teams who finish the core build and want to go further. Borrowed from gaming — where side quests are optional missions that enrich the main adventure without being required to complete it — in a hackathon they serve the same purpose: rewarding ambition without penalising teams who focused on getting the fundamentals right.

They carry their own prize category and feed into Best in Show consideration, but do not substitute for a strong core submission. No team is penalised for skipping them — make this explicit in the participant brief.

WHY INCLUDE THEM?

Reward stronger teams. A team that finishes early has nothing to aim at without side quests. They keep the most capable participants productive rather than over-polishing.

Create differentiation. When multiple teams produce similar core solutions, side quest completion gives judges meaningful signal to break ties.

Expand the problem space. Side quests push into territory the core challenge deliberately left out — integrations, edge cases, enterprise features — without overwhelming teams building under time pressure.

Side quests are not suitable for every hack. If the core challenge is already ambitious for the time available, omit them entirely.

HOW TO DEFINE THEM

Tier by complexity. Group into difficulty bands — e.g. Tier 1 quick win (1–2 hrs), Tier 2 meaningful extension (half-day), Tier 3 enterprise-grade (full day). Teams self-select based on pace and ambition.

Connect to judging categories. The best side quests map to a judging category. A Graph API integration maps to Best Technical Approach. A polished onboarding flow maps to Best UX. Teams can see how a side quest improves their overall score.

Keep them self-contained. Each side quest should be completable independently. Avoid chains where Quest B requires Quest A — it creates blockers mid-build.

State the demo value. Include a note on why each side quest would be compelling in a 10-minute presentation. If a judge cannot see the value in the demo window, it will not land.

Pick 3–6 total. Too few and the signal is weak. Too many and teams spend time deciding rather than building. Three to six well-chosen quests across the tiers is the right range for a two-day hack.

Label each side quest clearly in the participant materials with its tier, estimated effort, and which judging category it is most likely to contribute to.

SPONSORS & PRIZE CONTRIBUTIONS

If a sponsor is involved in the event, ask them directly whether they are willing to contribute prizes — and if so, on what basis. Sponsor prizes are often the most memorable part of the day, but they need to be agreed in advance and framed consistently with the rest of the prize structure.

Confirm the basis. Are they funding Best in Show, a category prize, or a bespoke prize of their own? Get this pinned down before the brief goes out so judging criteria are clear.

Bespoke sponsor prize. If the sponsor wants their own award (e.g. “Best Use of [Sponsor’s Product]”), agree the criteria upfront and surface it in the participant brief alongside the other categories. Judging for it sits with the sponsor or a joint panel.

Form of contribution. Cash, vouchers, product credit, branded items, or a team experience. Confirm logistics — who procures, who delivers, and whether anything needs to arrive before Day 2.

Recognition on the day. Agree how the sponsor is credited — MC mention, slide in the opening ceremony, speaking slot, or a representative on the judging panel. Set expectations both ways before the event.

Never assume a sponsor is contributing prizes — and never announce a sponsor prize before the sponsor has confirmed both value and form in writing.

SCALE PRIZES TO HACKATHON SIZE

The number of prize categories should be proportional to the number of teams. Award too many prizes relative to teams and winning is diluted — everyone walks away with something, so nothing feels earned.

Up to 5 teams — overall winner only. Award Best in Show only. Adding five category prizes on top means every team wins something — winning loses meaning.

6–9 teams — overall plus 2–3 categories. Best in Show plus a small number of sub-categories. Enough differentiation to reward distinct strengths without guaranteeing every team wins.

10+ teams — full category set. Best in Show plus the full five categories — Best Demo, Best Technical Approach, Best UX, Best Feature Fit, Most Innovative. Plenty of teams left unrewarded, so winning still signals real achievement.

PRIZES FROM THE BUSINESS

Game changer points are the default vehicle. Values are awarded per team member, not per team — recognises every contributor and is straightforward to administer.

Best in Show — £50 per team member. For a 5-person team, that’s £250 total in game changer points. Headline prize — should feel meaningfully larger than a category win.

Category winners — £20 per team member. Applied equally across all categories. Recognises focused excellence without overshadowing the overall winner. Same team can win multiple categories and receive each award.

Secure budget approval for total prize pool upfront — calculated on max team count. Confirm game changer point allocations can be issued ahead of LaunchPad so that winners are recognised immediately at announcement.